

RECRUITERS AREN'T THE MARKET

How to work with recruiters without handing them control
of your search



A practical guide for senior professionals and executives

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About this guide

I have worked with recruiters from several sides of the table: as a candidate, hiring manager, recruitment consultant and career transition adviser.

Over the years, I have also worked with senior professionals and executives who expected recruiters to play a much bigger part in their job search than they eventually did.

That combination gives me a fairly practical view of the recruitment market. I understand why recruiters behave the way they do, where they can add real value, and where candidates often expect too much from them.

This guide is designed to help you work with recruiters and executive search firms more intelligently, while keeping control of the wider search yourself.

Introduction: What recruiters can - and cannot - do for you

If you are a senior professional in career transition, there is a good chance you expect recruiters to play a significant part in finding your next role. After all, you have years of experience, a strong track record and plenty to offer. So when the phone doesn't ring, applications produce no response, or seemingly interested recruiters stop responding, it can be both frustrating and confusing. The problem is that many experienced candidates start with the wrong assumption about what recruiters are actually there to do.

It is easy to conclude that recruiters are the problem. Sometimes the service is poor. Sometimes communication is poor. But a lot of the frustration comes from expecting recruiters to do a job they were never engaged to do.

The employer is the client. The recruiter is being paid to solve the employer's hiring problem. You are part of that process, but you are not the customer.

Once you understand that, a lot of recruiter behaviour starts to make more sense.

This does not mean recruiters are unimportant. Far from it. The right recruiter can give you access to opportunities you may never see advertised, introduce you to employers you would struggle to reach on your own, and give you useful intelligence about the market, the role and the people involved.

But recruiters are only one route to market.

The mistake is to hand them too much responsibility for your career transition.

This resource is about helping you understand where recruiters and executive search firms fit, how they operate, what they can and cannot realistically do for you, and how to work with the right ones without becoming dependent on them.

The aim is not to turn you into an expert on the recruitment industry. It is to help you deal with recruiters with clearer expectations, better judgement and a stronger sense of control over your own search.

You are not the client

Start with the commercial relationship

There is one simple fact that explains a lot of recruiter behaviour:

The employer is the client.

The employer engages the recruiter, agrees the brief and pays the fee. So the recruiter's first responsibility is to the employer and to the assignment they have been engaged to fill.

That does not mean you should accept poor treatment. You should still expect professional courtesy and reasonable communication. Good recruiters also know that today's candidate may be tomorrow's hiring manager or client.

But professional courtesy is not the same as being the client.

That distinction becomes important when you are trying to make sense of the recruiter's behaviour.

If your background fits a live brief closely, you may suddenly get a great deal of attention. If it does not, or the recruiter cannot quickly see where you fit, that attention can disappear just as quickly.

It can feel personal.

Usually it isn't.

It is much more likely to be about whether the recruiter can see a realistic connection between you and a piece of work they are being paid to complete.

What the recruiter is actually trying to do

When a recruiter is working on an assignment, they are not asking:

"Is this an impressive person?"

They are asking something much more specific:

- Does this person fit the brief closely enough to put in front of the client?
- Can I explain clearly why they are relevant?
- Will the client see them as credible at the level required?
- Are they clear about what they want and why this role makes sense?
- Will they interview well?
- Are their expectations broadly realistic for the role and the market?

That is an important distinction for experienced professionals.

You may have had a long and successful career. You may have held senior roles, delivered significant results and built substantial expertise.

But the recruiter still has to be able to connect that experience to the problem sitting in front of them.

If that connection is not obvious, your experience alone may not be enough to get you onto the shortlist.

Recruiters are not career coaches

A good recruiter can still be very useful.

They may tell you that your target is too broad. They may challenge your remuneration expectations. They may point out that your resume is making your strongest experience harder to see. They may tell you that the market is currently favouring a different type of profile.

That kind of feedback can be extremely valuable.

They may also have a view about the sort of roles they think would suit you. Listen to it. Good recruiters often have an excellent feel for their market and can see possibilities you may not have considered.

But keep that advice in context. Their view will often be shaped by the part of the market they know, the assignments they tend to handle and what they have learned about you from your resume, LinkedIn profile and perhaps a relatively short conversation.

That is quite different from sitting down with someone and exploring your career direction properly - what you want next, what you no longer want, the range of options open to you and how those choices fit with the rest of your career and life.

So use recruiter advice as useful market input, not necessarily as the final word on where your career should go.

But helping you decide what you want to do next, rethink your career direction, rebuild your confidence or design your overall job-search strategy is not normally their job.

If you approach a recruiter without a clear idea of where you fit and expect them to work it out for you, you are asking them to do something outside the assignment they are being paid to complete.

That is one reason senior candidates can sometimes struggle with recruiters after a long corporate career. Internally, other people may already understand their background and value. In the external market, that context disappears.

You have to make the connection easier to see.

The recruiter is also managing risk

There is another part of this that candidates often overlook.

When a recruiter puts you forward, they are putting some of their own judgement on the line.

If you turn up poorly prepared, cannot explain your value clearly, misunderstand the role or interview badly, the client may question the recruiter's judgement as well as yours.

That is important because the recruiter wants the client to trust the people they recommend.

So a good recruiter is not simply matching a resume against a job description.

They are also asking themselves:

Am I comfortable putting my credibility behind this person?

That leads to one of the most important ideas in this resource:

Before expecting a recruiter to represent you, make sure you are market-ready.

You should be able to explain:

- the level and type of role you are targeting;
- why that direction makes sense;
- the value you bring;
- the evidence that supports it; and
- why an employer should take you seriously for that kind of role.

You do not need a perfectly polished script.

But the recruiter should not have to work hard to figure out who you are, where you fit or how to explain you to a client.

Executive search and recruitment are not the same thing

People often use the word "recruiter" to describe anyone involved in external hiring.

That can cause confusion because executive search and agency recruitment are not the same thing. From your side they may look similar - someone contacts you about a role, talks through your background and decides whether to put you forward - but the way they work and the commercial pressures behind them can be quite different.

It helps to know which sort of recruiter you are dealing with because that should influence both your expectations and your approach.

Executive search

Executive search is generally used when the appointment is senior, strategically important, sensitive, difficult to fill, or when the client wants a deliberate search for a relatively small number of people with a particular background.

The client is paying for a search process, not simply waiting to see whether someone suitable happens to apply.

That may involve mapping a market, identifying target organisations, talking to people who know the sector, researching particular individuals and approaching people who may not have been thinking about moving at all.

This is where senior candidates sometimes misunderstand how search works.

You do not necessarily "register with a head-hunter" and wait for them to find you something.

The search consultant starts with the client's brief and goes looking for people who fit it.

So the question becomes: if they were looking for someone like you, how likely is it that your name would come up?

That is why being known and discoverable in the right market is strategically important.

Your LinkedIn profile should make it reasonably clear what you do and where your experience sits. People in your network should have some sense of what you are good at. Your reputation in the market helps. So does staying connected with people who operate in the sectors and organisations where you are likely to be relevant.

None of that guarantees that a search consultant will call you.

But it improves the chances that you will surface when they start asking, "Who should we be talking to?"

That is quite different from waiting for a suitable advertisement and then applying.

Agency and contingency recruitment

Recruitment agencies tend to work across a broader range of roles and may operate on a contingency basis. In simple terms, that usually means the recruiter earns the placement fee when someone is successfully appointed.

The exact arrangements vary.

A recruiter may have the role exclusively for a period. They may have a long-standing relationship with the employer and know the business extremely well. Or several agencies may be trying to fill the same position at the same time.

Those differences can affect the way the process feels from your side.

If several recruiters are competing on the same role, there can be pressure to identify credible candidates and get them in front of the client quickly.

If the recruiter has an exclusive brief and a strong relationship with the client, they may have more time, more information and greater influence over the process.

So it is worth understanding the nature of the assignment.

You do not need to interrogate the recruiter about their commercial agreement. Just ask sensible questions.

For example:

- How closely are you working with the client?
- Did you take the brief directly from the hiring manager?
- Are you the only firm working on the assignment?
- Where are they up to in the process?

The answers can tell you quite a lot.

A recruiter who knows the client well may be able to tell you what is really driving the hire, where the client is flexible, what concerns have already surfaced and how the decision is likely to be made.

Someone who has been given a fairly thin brief and is competing with several other agencies may simply not have that level of information.

That is useful to know before you decide how much weight to put on what they tell you.

Key difference	Executive Search	Agency Recruitment
Typical use	Senior, specialised or business-critical roles where the right hire is important and often hard to find.	A wide range of roles, from entry to senior level, often where there is a more active candidate market.
Who is the client?	The employer is the client. Fees are commonly paid in stages, with only the final portion usually dependent on appointment.	The employer is the client. The fee is usually paid only when a candidate is appointed.
How the work starts	A formal search assignment with a clear brief, timeline and agreed process.	Usually starts with a role brief. The recruiter begins working on the role and is paid only if they make a successful placement.
How candidates are found	Proactive research and direct approach. Targeted use of networks, referrals and mapping of key organisations. Usually not advertised.	A mix of methods: database, networks, advertising, referrals and applications. More likely to work with candidates who are already in the market.
What the recruiter usually knows	Detailed understanding of the role, the organisation and the wider market. Often acts as an adviser to the employer.	Focuses on the specific role and key requirements. May have less insight into broader organisational context.

Key difference	Executive Search	Agency Recruitment
Typical candidate experience	Approached, often confidentially, because your background matches the brief. Expect a thorough discussion and a structured process.	More likely to be contacted if your profile matches a current role, or if you are active in the market. The process can be quicker and less structured.
What this means for you	Access to high-value, less visible opportunities, in-depth market insight and advocacy with the client. Highly selective: they will only represent you if they believe you are a strong match.	Useful opportunities, market information and feedback. Builds market visibility, but competition is usually higher and recruiters are managing multiple candidates.

Both can be valuable - and they often work in parallel. Understanding the differences helps you engage with each type of recruiter more effectively and set realistic expectations.

What does this mean for you?

With executive search, the work starts well before a particular vacancy exists. It is about being visible enough, credible enough and connected enough to come onto the radar when someone starts mapping the market.

With agency recruitment, there is more reason to know which recruiters specialise in your market, stay appropriately connected with them and respond when there is a genuine fit.

But in either case, do not assume that every person with "recruiter" in their title is operating the same way.

Find out what market they work in, what level of roles they handle and how they tend to work with their clients.

That will give you a much better idea of what they can realistically do for you - and how much attention you should give them.

What drives recruiter behaviour

One of the easiest ways to become frustrated with recruiters is to assume they are looking at the world from your point of view.

Usually they are not.

You are thinking about your next role, your career, your income, your confidence and how long the search is taking.

They are thinking about client briefs, candidate shortlists, business development, interviews, offers, competing assignments and the next piece of work.

That difference in perspective explains a lot.

Attention tends to follow commercial relevance

Recruiters have limited time and a lot competing for it.

So they will naturally spend more time on people and activities that appear most likely to produce a result for a client.

That can feel brutal from the candidate side.

A recruiter may be warm, engaged and highly responsive when your background lines up closely with a live assignment. A few weeks later, when they have nothing suitable, you may hear very little from them.

That does not necessarily mean they have changed their opinion of you.

It may simply mean there is nothing they can currently do with your background.

This is why chasing a recruiter repeatedly rarely changes very much. If they do not have a relevant opportunity, another phone call does not create one.

Your job is not to become impossible to ignore. It is to become easy to remember when the right brief appears.

Recruitment is a commercial business

Different recruitment firms use different remuneration models, so I would not make assumptions about exactly how any individual recruiter gets paid.

But the underlying point is simple enough.

Recruitment businesses need assignments. They need clients. They need to fill roles successfully. And they need to keep that cycle moving.

That commercial reality shapes behaviour.

It explains why recruiters can move very quickly when they have an urgent brief, why they may lose interest when a client changes direction, and why they are not usually going to spend large amounts of time helping someone whose background does not connect with work they are currently handling.

None of that excuses poor communication or unprofessional behaviour.

It just helps you interpret it more accurately.

Be easy to understand and represent

This is where your side of the equation comes in.

If I were advising you before you approached recruiters, I would want you to be able to answer a few basic questions clearly:

What are you looking for?

At what level?

In what sort of organisation or market?

What problems are you particularly good at solving?

What evidence do you have that you can do it?

Why should someone take you seriously for that kind of role?

If your answers are vague, the recruiter has to do too much work to figure out where you fit.

And they probably will not.

This is especially important for experienced people with broad backgrounds.

You may look at your career and see flexibility: several functions, industries, countries, transformations, leadership roles and different kinds of experience.

A recruiter may look at the same background and struggle to decide where to place you.

That is why broad experience can sometimes work against you unless you have done the work to give it a clear direction.

The easier you are to understand, the easier you are to represent.

They are putting their judgement on the line

We touched on this in Chapter 1, but it is worth reinforcing.

When a recruiter puts you forward, they are telling the client:

I think this person is worth your time.

So they are making a judgement not only about your experience, but about how you are likely to come across.

Can you explain your background clearly?

Do you understand the role?

Are you realistic about the level?

Will you interview well?

Are you someone the client is likely to take seriously?

If the recruiter is going to put their name behind you, they need to feel reasonably confident that you will reinforce their judgement, not undermine it.

Do not confuse lack of activity with lack of value

This is probably one of the most important points for senior candidates.

If several recruiters tell you that your background is strong but none of them has anything suitable, that can become very discouraging.

It is easy to start thinking:

"Maybe the market no longer values what I do."

Sometimes the market is giving you useful feedback and you need to listen to it.

But recruiter inactivity on its own is not enough evidence to draw that conclusion.

Their view is shaped by the briefs they happen to be working on, the clients they serve and the part of the market they know.

So listen carefully to recruiter feedback, particularly when you hear the same message from several credible people.

One opinion is an opinion.

A pattern is information.

What should you take from this?

Do not expect recruiters to give equal attention to every candidate they meet.

Do not assume silence is necessarily rejection.

And do not spend too much energy trying to force a recruiter relationship when there is no obvious commercial reason for them to engage.

Instead, make sure you are clear about where you fit, stay connected with recruiters who genuinely work in your market, and pay attention to the signals you receive over time.

That gives you much better information than measuring your value by how often a recruiter calls.

Where recruiters fit in the job market

A common mistake in senior career transition is to treat recruiters as the job market.

They are not.

They are one route into it.

Senior roles can emerge in all sorts of ways. Some are advertised. Some are handled by internal talent teams. Some go to executive search firms or recruitment agencies. Others are filled through referrals, introductions, direct approaches, succession conversations or discussions that start before there is even a formally approved vacancy.

That is why relying mainly on recruiters can leave you exposed.

Even very good recruiters only see the part of the market that passes through their own clients, networks and assignments.

The visible market and the hidden market

It is useful to think broadly about two parts of the market.

The visible market is the part you can see: advertised roles, company careers pages, job boards and recruiter advertisements.

The hidden market is less obvious. Opportunities may develop through relationships, referrals, direct approaches, internal discussions and conversations with people who know where a need is emerging.

You will sometimes see percentages quoted for the relative size of these markets. I would be cautious about relying on them.

There is no reliable universal percentage that tells you exactly how much of the market sits in each category, and at senior level the boundaries are often blurred anyway.

A role may begin as an internal conversation, move to a search firm, then eventually be advertised.

Or an employer may advertise a position while simultaneously asking trusted contacts who they know.

The useful question is not:

What percentage of jobs are hidden?

It is:

Which routes into the market am I using, and which ones am I relying on too heavily?

Recruiters sit across both markets

Recruiters do not operate only in the advertised market.

A recruiter may already know several people who could fit a brief and contact them before deciding whether advertising is necessary.

An executive search consultant may map the market and approach people directly.

A recruiter may hear from a client about a role that is still being shaped and start thinking about possible candidates before anything becomes public.

So the recruiter market and the hidden market overlap.

That is worth understanding because it changes the way you think about recruiter relationships.

If your only contact with recruiters happens when you see one of their advertisements, you are arriving relatively late.

There is value in being known to the right recruiters before they have a specific role for you.

Not dozens of recruiters.

The right ones.

People who genuinely work at your level, understand your function or sector and have relationships with the sort of organisations you want to reach.

Think in routes to market, not percentages

For a senior professional, I would normally want several routes operating at the same time.

That may include:

- relationships with a small number of relevant recruiters and search consultants;
- conversations across your existing network;
- introductions into organisations or sectors you want to explore;
- direct approaches where there is a sensible reason to make contact;
- selective applications for advertised roles that genuinely fit; and
- enough professional visibility that people can understand what you do and where you might be useful.

The balance will vary from person to person.

Someone moving within a well-defined specialist field may get substantial value from recruiters.

Someone changing sector, repositioning after a long career, or targeting roles that are rarely advertised may need to put far more effort into direct market activity and relationships.

There is no reason to choose one route and ignore the others.

Do not hand over control

This is where experienced candidates can get stuck.

They speak to several recruiters, send out their resume and assume they have now activated the market.

Then very little happens.

The temptation is to contact more recruiters or chase the existing ones harder.

Usually that is not the answer.

If the right brief lands on a recruiter's desk and you are a credible fit, the relationship can become very useful very quickly.

But the recruiter cannot create that brief just because you need a job.

So keep recruiter relationships active and professional, but keep working the rest of the market as well.

Recruiters can strengthen your search. They should not replace it.

Routes to Market

Recruiters are one route to market, not the market itself.

A more effective search uses several channels in a coordinated way, with a clear focus and consistent positioning.



More opportunities and better outcomes.

The right mix, used consistently and strategically, gives you a stronger position in the market and reduces reliance on any single channel.

**It's not about choosing one channel.
It's about using several, in a coordinated way.**

Working with recruiters in practice

There are two quite different situations you are likely to face with recruiters.

The first is when there is a specific role in front of you.

The second is when there is no immediate vacancy, but you want to establish a relationship with a recruiter who genuinely works in your market.

The approach should not be the same.

When there is a specific role

The first question is not:

How quickly can I apply?

It is:

Is this a role I should pursue?

At senior level, selective applications are usually far more useful than simply increasing volume.

Read the advertisement carefully. Look for what it tells you about the mandate, the level, the reporting line, the organisation and the problem they appear to be trying to solve.

Then look for what it does not tell you.

Why are they hiring?

Is this a new role or a replacement?

What does the person need to achieve in the first year?

What is genuinely non-negotiable?

Where does the role sit in the organisation?

What sort of background is the client likely to respond to?

You may not be able to answer all of those questions from the advertisement.

That is where human contact can be useful.

Create human contact where it is legitimate and useful

If the recruiter has provided contact details, or you can reasonably identify the person handling the assignment, there is nothing wrong with trying to have a short conversation before you apply.

The purpose is not to persuade them to read your resume while you are on the phone.

And it is not to bypass whatever application process they have set up.

The purpose is to get better information, test whether the role is worth pursuing and, if possible, establish some relevance before your application becomes one of many sitting in a system.

A couple of sensible questions can tell you a great deal.

For example:

- What is driving the hire?
- What will the successful person be expected to deliver?
- Which parts of the brief are genuinely essential?

- Is there anything about the role or client that is not obvious from the advertisement?
- What type of background is the client responding to?
- Is there a full position description or additional information you can share?

If the conversation goes well, you may also be able to ask the recruiter whether they would prefer you to submit through the advertised process or send the information directly to them.

Follow their lead.

The objective is not to beat the system. It is to avoid relying on the system alone when there is a sensible opportunity to create a human connection.

Use the information you gather

If you learn something useful, use it.

Do not send the same resume and covering message you would have sent before the conversation.

If the recruiter has told you that the client is particularly concerned about transformation, integration, growth, stakeholder management or whatever else sits behind the hire, make sure the evidence most relevant to that issue is easy to find.

The same applies to interview preparation.

A short conversation before you apply may give you information that becomes even more useful if you make the shortlist.

That is one reason I still encourage senior candidates to look for opportunities to speak to the person handling the role rather than simply pressing "Apply" and hoping for the best.

Do not disappear into the process unnecessarily

Once you have applied, there is a balance to strike.

You do not need to ring the recruiter the next morning to check whether the attachment opens.

That advice belonged to a different job-search environment.

But nor do you need to become completely passive.

If you have had a useful conversation with the recruiter, it is reasonable to stay in contact.

If they have told you when shortlisting is likely to happen, use that as your guide.

If the timing passes and you hear nothing, a short follow-up is fine.

What I would avoid is repeated contact simply to remind them that you exist.

If there is a genuine fit, your relevance should do more work than persistence.

Building recruiter relationships when there is no live role

This is a different exercise.

Do not start by making a list of fifty recruitment firms and sending everyone your resume.

Start with your market.

Which organisations interest you?

Which sectors?

What level of role?

Which recruiters and executive search consultants are actually active there?

You are looking for people who regularly handle assignments where someone with your background could realistically be relevant.

That usually means looking at:

- sector knowledge;
- functional expertise;
- level of appointments;
- client relationships;
- reputation in the market; and
- evidence that they are actually active in the space you are targeting.

A recruiter who is excellent in another market may still be of very little use to you.

Warm introductions are powerful

If someone credible can introduce you to a recruiter they know and trust, take advantage of it.

The difference between:

"Here is my resume. Please let me know if you have anything suitable."

and:

"Mary suggested I speak to you because she thought you would have a good feel for the market I am targeting."

can be considerable.

A warm introduction gives the recruiter context before the conversation even starts.

It does not guarantee anything.

But it gives them a reason to pay attention.

Give the recruiter something clear to work with

When you do get the conversation, do not expect the recruiter to work out your direction for you.

Be ready to explain:

- the sort of role you are targeting;
- the level;
- the type of organisation or environment;
- the experience you want to use;
- the problems you are particularly good at solving; and
- any boundaries or constraints they should know about.

If you are still exploring, you can say that.

But "I could do almost anything" is rarely helpful.

Broad experience needs a clear frame.

Salary and remuneration

Recruiters will usually want to understand your remuneration expectations relatively early.

That is reasonable.

What I would avoid is allowing your previous salary to become the only anchor for the conversation.

A better discussion is around the level of role you are targeting, what the market is paying for comparable positions and what range the client has in mind.

You can ask:

"What sort of range has the client budgeted for the role?"

If they will not disclose it, you may need to give an indication of your expectations.

Again, the aim is not to play games.

It is to establish whether there is enough alignment to justify continuing the conversation without unnecessarily tying your future value to whatever you happened to earn in your last job.

At senior level, total remuneration can also be more complicated than base salary alone, so make sure you and the recruiter are talking about the same thing.

Stay professional without becoming dependent

Good recruiter relationships can last for years.

The recruiter who cannot help you today may have exactly the right assignment six months from now.

So stay in touch where there is a genuine reason to do so.

Share a useful update.

Let them know if your target changes.

Tell them when you land somewhere.

And if they have been helpful, keep the relationship alive when you are back in employment rather than disappearing until the next time you need something.

That is how a recruiter relationship becomes a professional relationship rather than a transaction driven by your immediate job search.

But keep the broader principle in mind:

Work with recruiters. Do not wait for recruiters.

Once you are in the process

Once a recruiter decides you may be suitable for a role, the relationship changes.

You are no longer simply trying to get noticed.

You are now part of a live process, and the recruiter may have information, access and influence that can help you prepare well and make better decisions.

Use that.

Use the recruiter as a source of intelligence

A good recruiter may know far more about the role than you can learn from the advertisement or position description.

They may know:

- what is really driving the hire;
- what the client is most concerned about;
- where the brief is flexible and where it is not;
- who will be involved in the decision;
- what the hiring manager is like to deal with;
- how formal or conversational the interview style is likely to be;
- whether the manager tends to be direct, detailed, strategic, fast-paced or highly relationship-oriented;
- what leadership style seems to work well in the organisation; and
- what has happened in earlier interviews or conversations.

That does not mean you are trying to "game" the interview.

You are simply using information that helps you prepare properly.

If the recruiter can tell you that the hiring manager is very direct and wants concise answers, that is useful.

If they tell you the interviewer likes to explore issues in detail and expects examples, that is useful too.

If they tell you the leadership team is collaborative but the role needs someone willing to challenge, that gives you another clue about how to frame your examples.

None of this changes who you are.

It just helps you understand the environment you are walking into.

Make yourself easy to represent

The recruiter needs to be able to explain your fit to the client clearly.

So make their job easier.

Be able to explain:

- why the role makes sense for you;
- what part of your background is most relevant;
- where you have dealt with similar problems;
- what results you have achieved;
- and where there may be gaps or questions that need to be addressed.

Do not assume the recruiter will automatically make all the connections for you.

If there is an important part of your background that is not obvious from your resume or LinkedIn profile, make sure they understand it.

The clearer they are about your value, the better equipped they are to represent you.

Treat the recruiter interview as a business conversation

The recruiter is assessing you, but you should also be assessing the opportunity.

You are entitled to ask questions.

You are entitled to clarify things.

You are entitled to decide that the role is not right for you.

The best recruiter interviews feel like a two-way business discussion, not an interrogation.

That does not mean taking control of the meeting or talking over the recruiter.

It means engaging properly.

Listen carefully.

Answer the question asked.

Use clear examples.

Ask sensible questions.

And make sure you leave the conversation with a better understanding of the role than you had when you went in.

Be clear about your own contribution

Senior candidates often default to "we".

"We transformed the business."

"We delivered the turnaround."

"We built the team."

That may all be true, but the recruiter still needs to understand what you did.

What decisions did you make?

What did you lead?

What changed because of your contribution?

What was the scale?

What was the result?

You do not need to diminish the team.

You just need to make your own contribution clear.

Ask about the next step

Before the conversation ends, make sure you understand what happens next.

Who else is involved?

When is the client likely to review the shortlist?

Are there more recruiter interviews?

What is the likely timing?

Is there anything else they need from you?

That gives you a sensible basis for follow-up rather than guessing.

After the recruiter interview

Take a few minutes to debrief yourself.

What went well?

What did you learn?

Did anything about the role change your level of interest?

Was there a question you handled poorly?

Is there anything you should clarify with the recruiter?

A brief thank-you message is usually appropriate, especially if there is something useful you want to reinforce.

Keep it brief.

You are not trying to re-run the interview by email.

Preparing for the client interview

If you make it through to the employer interview, go back to the recruiter.

This is one of the points where a good recruiter can be particularly useful.

Ask what they can tell you about:

- the people you will meet;
- their roles in the decision;
- the likely interview style;
- the issues they are most likely to explore;
- any concerns the client has raised;
- what they responded positively or negatively to in earlier conversations; and
- anything the recruiter thinks you should be ready to address directly.

This is not about scripting artificial answers.

It is about reducing avoidable surprises.

Debrief with the recruiter afterwards

After the client interview, take a little time to think before contacting the recruiter.

Then give them a clear debrief.

Tell them how you think it went.

Tell them what you learned.

Tell them whether your interest has increased, decreased or stayed the same.

If something came up that needs clarification, raise it.

If you are keen, say so.

The recruiter is likely to speak to the client as well, so your feedback gives them useful information to work with.

In some cases they may be able to clarify a misunderstanding or reinforce something important that did not land strongly enough in the interview.

If the answer is no

If you are not progressing, ask for feedback.

You may not get much.

Sometimes the recruiter genuinely has little detail to give you.

Sometimes the client has simply preferred someone else.

But if there is useful feedback available, get it.

And do not immediately argue with it.

Take it away and think about whether there is anything to learn.

If several credible people start giving you similar feedback, pay attention.

Keep the rest of your search moving

This point is easy to forget when an opportunity starts to look promising.

Do not stop everything else.

Keep your other conversations going.

Keep your network active.

Keep pursuing other relevant opportunities.

A process can stall, change direction or disappear for reasons that have nothing to do with you.

Until there is a firm offer that you are prepared to accept, keep the rest of your search moving.

That is not pessimism.

It is simply good job-search discipline.

Keep control of your search

Recruiters can be valuable allies.

The right ones can open doors, give you access to opportunities you would not otherwise see, provide useful market intelligence and help you prepare for an employer process.

But none of that changes the central point of this resource:

Recruiters should support your career strategy. They should not become your career strategy.

Be market-ready

Before you expect recruiters to represent you well, make sure you are clear enough to represent.

You should be able to explain:

- the sort of role you are targeting;
- the level you are operating at;
- the value you bring;
- the problems you are particularly good at solving;
- and the evidence that supports that.

If that is still unclear, do that work first.

Do not expect a recruiter to turn a broad or unfocused background into a clear market proposition for you.

Be easy to find and easy to understand

At senior level, some opportunities will reach you because someone already knows you or can find you.

That makes your visibility important.

Your LinkedIn profile should make sense quickly.

Your network should have some idea of what you do well.

The people most relevant to your market should not need a long explanation to understand where you fit.

You are not trying to become highly visible to everyone.

You are trying to be visible to the right people for the right reasons.

Choose the right recruiters

More recruiters do not automatically create more opportunity.

A small number of people who genuinely understand your market, work at your level and have credible client relationships are far more useful than a long list of agencies with little connection to the work you want.

Be selective.

Build relationships where there is a sensible reason to do so.

And keep those relationships professional over time.

Work with recruiters intelligently

Work with recruiters where they add value.

They can provide:

- access;
- market intelligence;
- information about a role and client;
- feedback;
- interview preparation; and
- an informed view of how your background is being received in their part of the market.

Listen to that input.

Use it.

But keep it in context.

A recruiter sees you through the lens of the market they work in, the briefs they handle and the information they have about you.

That is useful, but it is not the whole picture.

Keep control of the wider search

This is the part I would not compromise on.

Do not hand control of your career transition to recruiters.

Keep working your network.

Keep having conversations.

Keep looking for introductions.

Keep approaching organisations where there is a good reason to do so.

Keep applying selectively for roles that genuinely fit.

And keep building enough visibility that opportunities can reach you from more than one direction.

If recruiters are not generating the opportunities you expected, the answer is rarely to chase more of them more often.

The better question is:

What other routes into the market am I using?

That puts you back where you should be.

In control of your own search.

Recruiters can strengthen that search.

They can sometimes accelerate it.

They can occasionally open a door you would never have found on your own.

But they are only one part of the market.

Use them well.

Keep the relationship commercial and professional.

And make sure the rest of your job-search activity keeps moving around them.

What to do next

Before you contact another recruiter, take ten minutes and answer these five questions:

1. Which roles am I actually targeting?
2. Which recruiters genuinely work at that level and in that market?
3. Am I clear enough for them to understand and represent quickly?
4. What useful market intelligence can I get from the recruiters I already know?
5. What am I doing outside recruiters to keep the rest of my search moving?

CHAPTER 7

What to Do Next

Before you chase another recruiter, work out where the real blockage is.
Use these five questions to pressure-test your current search strategy.

1



Which roles am I actually targeting?

Be specific about level, scope and the type of opportunity you want.

2



Which recruiters genuinely work in that market?

Focus on the few who are relevant, credible and active at your level.

3



Am I clear enough to be understood and represented quickly?

Your value should be easy to grasp from your résumé, LinkedIn profile and conversations.

4



What useful market intelligence can I get from the recruiters I already know?

Use recruiter conversations to gather insight, not just wait for opportunities.

5



What am I doing outside recruiters to keep the rest of my search moving?

Keep other routes to market active: network, referrals, direct approaches and selective applications.



Recruiters can strengthen your search. They should not replace it.

The strongest search is coordinated, deliberate and under your control.

If you cannot answer those clearly, that is the work to do next.

Do not respond by adding another twenty recruiters to your list.

Tighten your direction. Improve your positioning. Identify the right people. Reconnect with the market.
And keep recruiter activity in its proper place: as one part of a broader strategy that you control.

Before you chase another recruiter, work out where the real blockage is

If your search has been running for a while without enough traction, the problem may sit somewhere else - your direction, positioning, access to the market or the way the campaign is being run.

I have a short diagnostic that will help you identify where the pressure points are.

There's no charge, and it only takes a few minutes.

Take the diagnostic

About Gavin Lister

Gavin Lister is a Hidden Job Market Strategic Advisor who works with experienced professionals and senior executives navigating career transition.

His background includes executive career transition, recruitment, hiring and senior-level job-search strategy. He spent more than 17 years with Right Management, working across Australia, South East Asia, Europe and the UK, and has also advised MBA students and alumni through Melbourne Business School.

Today, his work focuses on helping senior professionals clarify where they fit, position their experience more effectively and access opportunities beyond the visible job market.

He is also the author of *Your Experience Isn't Enough*, *Strategic Visibility Conversations* and *How Work Finds You*.

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